

Q What exercises can I do immediately after having my baby?

You may be desperate to lose any excess pregnancy weight and tone up again after the birth of your baby, but you must take things gently until the six-week checkup, when your doctor should give you the all-clear.

Childbirth has a profound effect on your body and it takes a while to recover your pre-pregnancy strength and resilience. Although it's good to be active again as soon as possible after the birth, the general advice is that for the first six weeks you should not attempt to return to—or improve on—your pre-pregnancy fitness levels. Your transverse abdominal muscles (see opposite) may still be stretched apart, and levels of relaxin are still high in your body, so your joints will remain loose for a while yet; you may inflict serious long-term damage to your ligaments if you try any high-impact exercise. Your lochia (vaginal bleeding) may get heavier or turn bright red if you do exercise too hard too soon after giving birth—a warning sign that you need to dial down your activities again. If you want to swim, leave seven clear days without vaginal bleeding beforehand so you don't pick up an infection (and avoid it if you have had stitches or a cesarean section). Anything other than gentle exercise and Kegel exercises is off limits until at least

after your six-week checkup. To get your circulation going, take a gentle walk every day, and gradually build your stamina. Remember to keep your back straight as you push the baby stroller.

Kegel and stretch exercises

Focusing on your Kegel exercises again after the birth is essential to retone the muscles as soon as possible, so practice them throughout the day, sitting, standing, kneeling, or lying down as often as you remember (see pp.66–67). If you can't feel the muscles, try practicing first on an exercise ball. Now that you don't have to limit the number of pull ups you do in order to be able to consciously relax the muscles during labor, do as many repetitions as you can manage—the more the better. You can also start gently exercising and stretching (see below) to begin toning major muscles, boost your recovery from the labor and birth, and help you get rid of any aches and stiffness.

GENTLE EXERCISES FOR THE FIRST SIX WEEKS

You can do these gentle exercises to tone your lower stomach muscles and stretch out your body after the birth, even if you have had a cesarean section. Start with just a few repetitions if you can manage them in the early days, and gradually build up your strength over six weeks with more repetitions.



Pelvic tilt Lie on the floor and support your head and shoulders with a cushion. Relax your arms at your sides and press your back into the floor. Keep your knees bent and your feet flat on the floor. As you exhale, press the small of your back into the floor for 10 seconds. Then release and relax. Repeat this 3–4 times initially, building up to 12 and then 24 repeats.



Leg slides Lie on your back with your head and shoulders supported, knees bent with feet flat, and arms at your sides. Exhale and slide one leg down until it is flat on the floor. Repeat with the other leg. Inhale and slowly bring one leg back up. Repeat with the other leg. Repeat the exercise 3–4 times. Increase gradually over the weeks until you can do 12 or more leg slides comfortably.



Spine alignment Lie on your back with your head and shoulders supported and knees bent with feet flat on the floor, and the small of your back pressed into the floor. Exhale and extend your right leg down so it is flat on the floor. Breathe in, then as you exhale stretch your right arm along the floor behind your head. On your next exhale, stretch from heel to fingertips. Repeat on the other side.



Extended Child's Pose Get down onto all fours, then sit back on your heels, separate your knees, extend your arms out in front of you, and rest your forehead and your forearms on the floor. Your belly should rest between your thighs. Hold for 2 breaths or as long as it feels comfortable. This pose will enable you to elongate your back fully and release any tension in your hips.